

Miner Nine Has New Win Look, Ready for WAC

By DERRY EADS

U.T.-El Paso's baseball team was given a new look this year when the athletic department bought new uniforms.

After last year's squad compiled a 12-39 mark, coach Andy Cohen made a major overhaul of the team. He dismissed some of the athletes and, with the help of assistant Ronnie White, went out on a big recruiting trip.

This year's team has 10 freshmen on the roster and several junior college transfers.

The change has helped.

COHEN HAS been using freshmen Glen Villarreal as a regular at third base, Larry McKay in the outfield, Pete Shaffer as catcher, Keith Rushing as a pinch hitter and Mike Hilton, Larry Richardson, Mike Miller, Tony Eaton and Jeff Hogan on the mound.

Villarreal, who has been having fielding problems at the "hot corner", has made it up at the bat. He is hitting .265 and is leading the team in hits with 22.

Catcher to Pitcher

Miller and Hilton have been two very pleasant surprises on the mound. Miller, who was used extensively as a catcher during high school in El Paso, has transformed well with the help of pitching coach Syd Cohen. Miller has recorded a 3-0 record and has an earned run average of 2.19.

HILTON HAS run into problems that shouldn't happen to a hurler whose e.r.a. is a phenomenal 0.64. The Miners have not been producing the runs for the 5-5, 150-pound lefty and Hilton's record is a meager 1-2.

Junior college transfers Mark Miller and Herb von Hagen have given the Miners some solid fielding in the infield that was sorely missed last year.

Von Hagen, who is Cohen's shortstop, has mishandled the ball nine times, but has covered a lot of ground and helped out at the bat with a .257 average and 12 rbi's.

MILLER TOOK over second base when senior Skip Baker was injured early in the season and has been unwilling to give up the job easily. His bid to keep his position is high and hard to beat. He leads the team with a .351 average, despite the fact that the El Paso sophomore is in a slump. Miller was hitting .500 until a dry spell has stuck with him in the last week with a five-for-27 showing.

Lettermen Eloy Alvarado (.328) and Joe Kuentler (16 rbi's) have been mainstays.

WAC Race Starts

The return of Barry Alburdis from the injury list may be what the Miners need for the start of Western Athletic Conference play at 1 p.m. Friday against the University of New Mexico at Dudley Field.

ALBURDIS, an honorable mention to the all-WAC squad last year, connected for two healthy home runs Saturday including the game-winning blow in the 11th inning of the second contest.

New Mexico presents a formidable foe for the Miners. The Lobos support a 22-3 record as compared to U.T.-El Paso's 15-10 mark. New Mexico has compiled a team batting average of .327 which should give Cohen's pitching staff, which has allowed only 2.28 earned runs per game, a stiff test.

Masters at White Elephant

The West Texas-New Mexico Masters Bowling Assn. has its next tournament this Saturday and Sunday at White Elephant Bowling Lanes in El Paso.

A HOST OF local WT-NM bowlers plus some outstanding keggers from out-of-town as J. B. Blaylock of Alamogordo, Joe Light of Carizozo, Jerry Schlick of Albuquerque and Rocky Bradley of Las Cruces are expected to enter.

The pro-am portion of the tournament is scheduled for Saturday afternoon with shifts at noon, 2 and 4 p.m. The pros will start their meet Saturday night in two shifts, 6:30 p.m. and 8:30 p.m.

Each pro will bowl four qualifying games Saturday night and four Sunday morning. The top eight qualifiers will bowl seven round robin contests and one position round.

Top prize in the tournament is \$200.